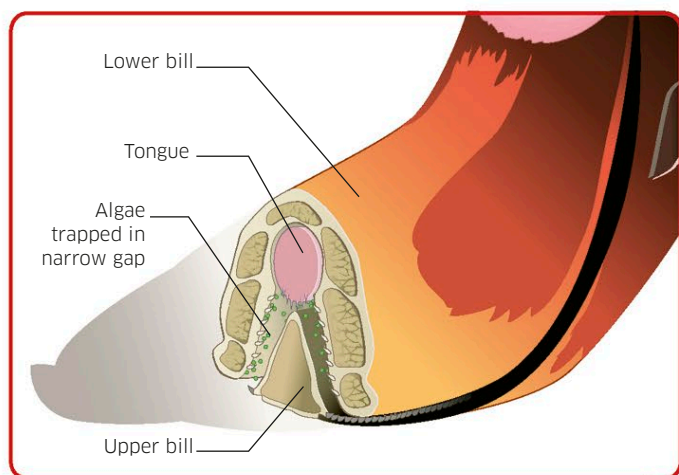




LESSER FLAMINGO

Strategy: Filter feeder

The lesser flamingo is nourished almost entirely by the microscopic algae in African salt lakes. Each cupful of water from the lakes is a rich soup containing billions of algae, which the bird filters out with its unusual bill. By lowering its head upside down into the lake and pumping its tongue backward and forward like a piston, water gets drawn into and out of the long bill. A coating of minute brushes on the inner lining of the bill trap the algae, which are then rapidly swallowed by the hungry bird.



Filtering bill

A cross section of a flamingo's bill in its upside-down feeding position shows how its two halves fit neatly together. This leaves a narrow gap big enough for algae, but too small for larger particles.

1 Straining the water

As the tongue pulls algae-rich water into the bill, a row of hooks lining the edge of the upper bill screen out larger particles.

3 Swallowing the food

Backward-pointing spines on the tongue help to direct algae to the back of the mouth, where they are swallowed.

2 Trapping the algae

The tongue then moves forward to expel the water back out, and the algae are trapped by tiny brushes on the bill lining.

